SUS Scoring in SaaS Fintech

System Usability Scale — Research Brief · June 2026

SUS — the System Usability Scale — is a validated 10-question survey that produces a 0–100 score measuring perceived usability. Developed by John Brooke in 1986, it remains the industry standard: quick (~2 min to complete), validated across thousands of studies, and product-agnostic.

How It Works

Users rate 10 statements on a 1–5 Likert scale. Half are positively worded (*"I found the system easy to use"*), half are negatively worded (*"I needed to learn a lot before I could use it"*). The scoring formula normalises responses into a 0–100 range.

Questions alternate positive/negative — this design forces deliberate reading rather than auto-filling the same answer down the column.

Score Interpretation

Score	Grade	What It Means
90–100	**A+**	Best in class — top 4% of all products tested
80–89	**A/B**	Good — users actively recommend to others
68–79	**C**	Average — usable but meaningful friction exists
55–67	**D**	Below average — users struggle to complete tasks
< 55	**F**	Poor — significant redesign required

68 is the global average *across ~500 peer-reviewed studies — that's your baseline. Hitting 68 is not 'good', it's average.*

What This Looks Like in Fintech SaaS

- **2025 MeasuringU business software benchmark:** Average SUS of **70.5** across 23 products (range 61–81). Enterprise tools with complex workflows cluster at the lower end.
- **SUS ↔ NPS correlation:** SUS > 80 → promoters; 56–73 → passives; < 56 → detractors. The clearest leading signal for retention risk.
- **Context matters:** A score of 65 in a multi-entity reconciliation flow is very different from 65 in a simple payments dashboard. Benchmark against comparable complexity, not the global average.

- **CES often predicts churn better in B2B:** Customer Effort Score is more predictive of churn in fintech because B2B users don't quit — they submit tickets and complain to their boss instead.

Why Fintech Specifically Should Care

1. **Regulatory complexity creates friction.** Compliance flows (KYC, AML, audit trails) add steps that suppress SUS scores. Knowing *where* in those flows friction spikes is the actionable part.
2. **Power users vs. new users diverge sharply.** CFOs and AP clerks using the same tool will give wildly different SUS scores. Segment your surveys or you'll average out meaningful signal.
3. **Onboarding is the highest-leverage window.** First-90-day churn correlates strongly with early SUS. Running surveys at day 7 and day 30 gives an early warning system before churn appears in your MRR.
4. **SUS < 68 correlates with support cost spikes.** Lower SUS = more tickets = higher CS cost per account. This is a quantifiable P&L line, not just a UX metric.

How to Run It

1. Pick a key flow (e.g., invoice approval, bank reconciliation, onboarding).
2. Send the 10-question survey *immediately* after users complete that flow.
3. 5+ responses gives you signal; 20+ gives statistical confidence.
4. Track it quarterly — trend matters more than any single snapshot.
5. Pair with task completion rate and time-on-task for the full picture.

Quick Take for Product Decisions

Aim for **75+** as a product quality floor. Investigate anything below **68** as a churn risk. Treat **80+** as a usability moat worth surfacing in sales and marketing.

Sources

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SUS: Why It Works and Why It Matters

The Basics of Why It's Effective

SUS was created in 1986 by John Brooke at Digital Equipment Corporation. It's survived 40 years because it's **deceptively simple but statistically robust**. Ten questions, alternating positive/negative framing (to prevent *satisficing* — where users just tick the same box repeatedly), scored on a 5-point Likert scale. The alternating structure forces cognitive engagement with each question.

The output is a single number: **0–100**. That simplicity is a feature, not a limitation — it makes it actionable across a business without needing to explain methodology to stakeholders.

Why the Benchmarks Are Trustworthy

SUS has been administered **500,000+ times** across industries. The benchmarks aren't theoretical — they're empirical averages from decades of real deployments. When you score 74, you know exactly where you stand relative to comparable products. Most UX metrics don't have this. SUS you can compare across companies.

Jeff Sauro at MeasuringU mapped SUS scores to letter grades and percentiles:

Score	Percentile	Meaning
90–100	Top 4%	Exceptional
80–89	Top 10–25%	Good — users recommend
70–79	Top 25–40%	Above average
68	50th percentile	Average
55–67	Bottom 25–40%	Below average
< 55	Bottom 10%	Poor — redesign required

68 is the median, not a pass mark. *A lot of teams celebrate 68 — they shouldn't.*

Why It Predicts Business Outcomes

This is where SUS becomes commercially important, not just a UX vanity metric.

1. It predicts NPS before NPS moves

SUS is collected at the flow level, right after task completion. NPS is collected quarterly or annually about the product as a whole. The causal chain: poor usability → frustration → reduced usage → negative NPS → churn. SUS catches the first link. By the time NPS drops, you've already lost momentum.

2. It predicts support volume

SUS < 68 correlates strongly with increased support ticket rates. Users who struggle don't always complain — they raise tickets, churn silently, or both. A SUS improvement from 62 → 75 on a high-traffic flow can have a measurable cost reduction.

3. It predicts early churn

For SaaS, the first 90 days determine whether a customer renews. Running SUS at day 7 and day 30 gives an early warning system. A user scoring their day-7 experience at 55 is a churn signal you can act on before they hit their renewal date.

4. It's sensitive to change

Because it's standardised, you can run it before and after a redesign and know whether you actually improved things. Most qualitative research can't do this cleanly.

Why It's Especially Important in Fintech

Fintech has a structural problem: **regulatory requirements force friction**. KYC, AML, two-factor auth, audit trails, consent flows — these aren't optional. This creates a ceiling effect where fintech SUS scores tend to run lower than consumer apps.

This makes SUS *more* important, not less:

- You can't remove compliance steps, so you need to know exactly which *non-compliance* steps are dragging the score.
- Segmenting by user type (new vs. power user, SMB vs. enterprise) reveals where friction is concentrated — often new users hitting compliance flows they don't understand.
- A SUS of 72 in fintech may be excellent; the same score in a consumer photo app may be mediocre — context and benchmarking by category matters.

How to Get the Most Signal From It

Run it at the flow level, not the product level. "Rate our product" is too broad. "Rate the experience of uploading a dataset" gives you actionable data on a specific flow.

Segment the results:

- New users vs. power users — they diverge sharply
- By persona (analyst vs. admin vs. exec)
- By account tier (SMB vs. enterprise)

Pair with two other metrics:

- **Task completion rate** — did they finish the flow at all?
- **Time on task** — how long did it take?

SUS tells you how they *felt*. Completion rate and time tell you what *actually happened*. A user can complete a task and still score it low (finished but hated it). A user can score it high and still abandon (liked what they saw but got stuck elsewhere).

Track trend, not snapshot. A single SUS score is interesting. Quarterly SUS over 18 months is strategic — it shows whether product improvements are landing and whether you're moving toward or away from competitive parity.

The One Thing Teams Get Wrong

They measure SUS once, get a number, feel good or bad about it, and move on.

SUS is only valuable as a **continuous signal**. The number matters less than the direction. Are you moving from 64 → 70 → 75 over three quarters? That's a product team systematically reducing friction. That story — with the numbers — is what goes to the board, to customers, and into a renewal conversation.